

THE GREAT WALL OF CHINA

The Great Wall is the name given to the vast system of fortifications and walls snaking across 8,000 miles (13,000 km) of northern China. It was designed to protect China from its enemies to the north, especially the Mongols. The part of the Wall shown here, called the Mutianyu section, was completed in 1572. It looks almost the same now as when it was built 450 years ago.

Food and drink

Soldiers on the Great Wall ate simple food such as rice and vegetables, brought in from nearby farms and villages. To drink, troops were given dried blocks of tea leaves known as *Bing cha* ("tea bread"). Fresh water was not always safe to drink, as it could contain bacteria, so it was best to boil it first and drink it hot with tea.



As well as cannons, spiked "rollers" were dropped over the side of the Wall to stop people climbing up. They were also rolled along the floor to trip-up (and seriously injure) attackers.

Strong stone walls

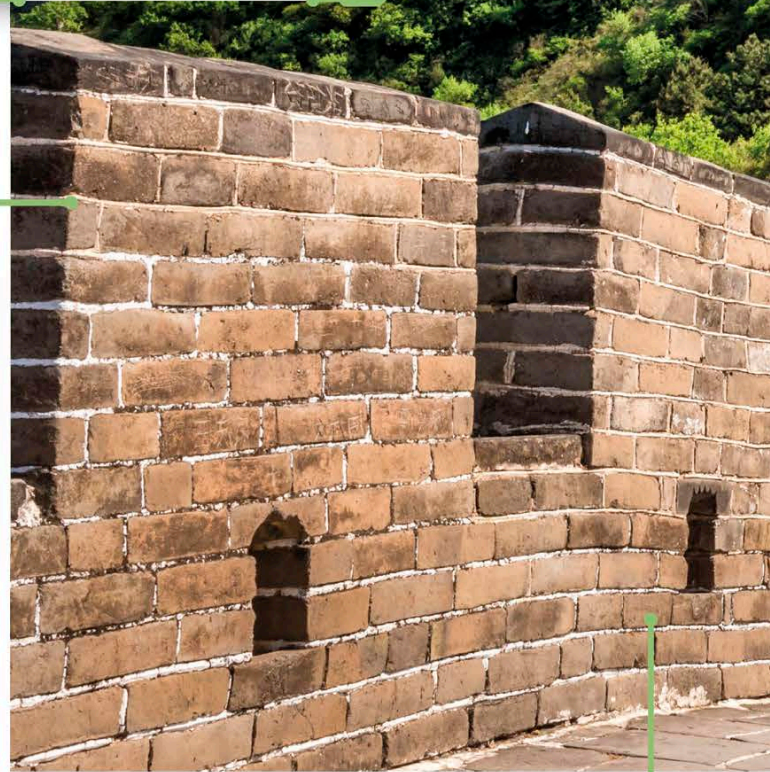
Known as ramparts, the brick walls at Mutianyu were 30 ft (9 m) high and 13-16 ft (4-5 m) across. The tops of the wall had sections cut out called crenellations through which cannons could be fired.



Protecting the capital

Mutianyu is in a hilly part of northeast China. It is just 43 miles (70 km) from the Chinese capital, Beijing, so was one of the Wall's most important sections.

The Wall was usually built on the steepest part of a hill, to make it extra difficult to attack.



General in charge

Work began on the Great Wall around 221 BCE, but it was quite a simple and low structure at first. After a Mongol attack on China in 1550, the general Qi Jiguang was asked to strengthen the Wall, adding the watchtowers and defensive ramparts we see today at places such as Mutianyu.



Seal of approval

Builders had to stamp each batch of bricks so the authorities could find and punish them if the bricks were poor-quality. Many of those bricks can still be seen today.